

- RAG Learning

## 2.7 Feminism

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 2: Non-core Political Ideas, Section B

**Exam Tip:** This is one of **five** non-core ideas. You sit **one** of Anarchism, Ecologism, Feminism, Multiculturalism or Nationalism, answering a single 24-mark "To what extent" question (AO1 8 / AO2 8 / AO3 8). Learn your chosen idea properly rather than all five thinly.

Feminism holds that society is characterised by unequal gender relations that are socially produced and can therefore be changed. Its distinctive contribution to political theory is the claim that the **private sphere is political** — which redrew the boundaries of the subject itself.

**Sex** — the biological differences between males and females.

**Gender** — the socially and culturally constructed roles and expectations attached to those categories.

**Patriarchy** — literally rule by the father; a society in which power is systematically held by men, in public and private life.

**The personal is political** — relations within the private sphere are structured by power and are properly political.

**Equality feminism** — liberation means women achieving the same terms as men.

**Difference feminism** — qualities associated with women have been devalued and should be revalued.

**Intersectionality** — gender operates together with race, class and other axes of power.

**Otherness** — de Beauvoir's idea that woman is defined in relation to man, who is treated as the norm.

**Cultural feminism** — the creation of a women's culture as an alternative to patriarchal society.

# 1. Core ideas and principles

| Principle                        | What it means                                                                                                                                                |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sex and gender</b>            | Sex is biological, gender is constructed. If subordination follows from gender it is social and can be changed — the foundational move of the whole ideology |
| <b>Patriarchy</b>                | Subordination is structural — a system of power rather than a set of individual prejudices                                                                   |
| <b>The personal is political</b> | Family, marriage, sexuality and domestic labour are sites of power and proper objects of political analysis                                                  |
| <b>Equality and difference</b>   | Whether liberation means the same terms as men, or revaluing what has been associated with women                                                             |
| <b>Intersectionality</b>         | Gender combines with race, class and sexuality, so there is no single female experience                                                                      |

## Waves

| Wave          | Period        | Focus                                                                                          |
|---------------|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>First</b>  | c.1850–1920s  | Legal and political rights — suffrage, property, divorce, access to education                  |
| <b>Second</b> | 1960s–80s     | The private sphere, reproductive rights, workplace equality, cultural expectation              |
| <b>Third</b>  | 1990s onwards | Diversity of women's experience, intersectionality, challenges to a single category of "woman" |

# 2. Strands of feminism

|                               | Liberal                                                 | Socialist                                       | Radical                                                       | Post-modern                                                    |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Cause of subordination</b> | Legal and institutional exclusion; cultural expectation | Capitalism's reliance on unpaid domestic labour | Patriarchy — the most fundamental division, deeper than class | Questions whether a single cause, or a single category, exists |
| <b>Site of change</b>         | Law, institutions, attitudes                            | The economy                                     | The private sphere and culture                                | Language, discourse, identity                                  |
| <b>Method</b>                 | Reform within existing structures                       | Transformation of economic relations            | Transformation of personal and sexual relations               | Deconstruction of fixed categories                             |
| <b>Thinkers</b>               | Wollstonecraft, Friedan                                 | Rowbotham                                       | Millett                                                       | (hooks contributes the intersectional critique)                |

### 3. Key thinkers

**Charlotte Perkins Gilman (1860–1935)** — *Women and Economics* (1898). Women's subordination is rooted in **economic dependence** created by the sexual division of labour in the home: confined to domestic work, women depend on men for subsistence, which shapes the whole relationship. Her remedy is structural rather than legal — socialise domestic work through communal kitchens, laundries and childcare so women can enter paid employment. Also wrote *The Yellow Wallpaper* (1892) on the psychological cost of confinement.

**Simone de Beauvoir (1908–86)** — *The Second Sex* (1949). "One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman" — the single most important sentence in feminist theory, establishing the sex/gender distinction. Woman is constructed as **the Other**: man is treated as the

human norm and woman is defined in relation to him, which denies her status as a subject in her own right. Liberation requires transcendence — economic independence, work, and rejecting the roles culture assigns.

**Kate Millett (1934–2017)** — *Sexual Politics* (1970). **Radical feminism.** Patriarchy is a pervasive political institution operating through personal and sexual relations as much as through public ones, and it is the most fundamental division in society — more basic than class. It is sustained through socialisation within the family and through culture, so reforming public institutions cannot reach it. Called for a "cultural revolution" in personal life.

**Sheila Rowbotham (1943– )** — *Hidden from History* (1973), *Woman's Consciousness, Man's World* (1973). **Socialist feminism.** Women's oppression is bound up with capitalism, which depends on unpaid domestic labour to reproduce the workforce at no cost. She also recovered women's history, arguing that its erasure was itself a mechanism of subordination. Insists that class and gender must be analysed together rather than ranked.

**bell hooks (1952–2021)** — *Ain't I a Woman?* (1981), *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center* (1984). The **intersectional** critique: second-wave feminism generalised from the position of white, middle-class, educated women. Friedan's account of confinement to domesticity described a condition working-class and Black women, long required to work outside the home, did not share. Feminism must therefore address gender alongside race and class, and must include men in the project of ending sexism rather than treating them as the enemy.

**Exam Tip:** hooks's critique of Friedan is the most useful single relationship in this topic, because it lets you evaluate rather than describe: it shows a named weakness in a named position, and it raises the strategic problem of whether feminism can be both accurate about diversity and unified in its demands. That is AO2 and AO3 in one move.

## 4. Feminism on human nature, the state, society and the economy

|                     | Position                                                           | Internal disagreement                                                                                             |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Human nature</b> | Gender differences are constructed, not natural                    | Whether any differences are real and should be revalued (difference feminism) or all are constructed              |
| <b>The state</b>    | Historically patriarchal; can be an instrument of reform           | Liberal: reform through it. Radical: it reflects patriarchy. Socialist: it serves capital and patriarchy together |
| <b>Society</b>      | Structured by patriarchy across public and private spheres         | Whether patriarchy is the fundamental division or operates alongside class and race                               |
| <b>The economy</b>  | The sexual division of labour and unpaid domestic work are central | Whether capitalism causes subordination or merely exploits it                                                     |

## The public–private divide

Feminism's most distinctive theoretical contribution. Treating the household as outside politics places the labour and power relations within it beyond scrutiny and reform. The practical effect of rejecting that divide was to bring domestic violence, marital rape (criminalised in 1991), reproductive rights and the division of unpaid work into political debate, having previously been treated as private matters. The liberal objection — that it licenses intrusion into private life — is real and worth acknowledging.

## 5. Evaluation

### Has feminism achieved its objectives?

| Achieved                                                                                                   | Not achieved                                                |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| First-wave objectives met entirely: the franchise, legal equality, access to all professions and education | A gender pay gap persists, concentrated around childbearing |

|                                                                    |                                                                                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Equal Pay Act 1970, Sex Discrimination Act 1975, Equality Act 2010 | The division of unpaid caring work has changed far less than paid employment     |
| Marital rape criminalised 1991                                     | Under-representation in senior positions in politics, business and the judiciary |
| Women outnumber men in higher education                            | Violence against women and girls persists at rates legal change has not shifted  |

**The judgement worth writing:** the pattern of success and failure is itself the evidence in feminism's internal argument. Where the constraint was legal exclusion, legal remedy worked and worked quickly; where the constraint is the distribution of unpaid work and the expectations attaching to it, decades of legal equality have produced comparatively little movement. That vindicates the liberal feminist strategy for the problems it targeted, and the radical and socialist diagnosis of what remains.

## Does feminism have a coherent view of women's interests?

The intersectional and post-modern challenge is that if women's experiences differ fundamentally by race and class, the claim that women constitute a single group with common interests becomes hard to sustain — which complicates any politics organised around it. The reply is that a false unity silenced most women anyway, so accuracy is worth the strategic cost. The difficulty may be unavoidable: a movement can be accurate about diversity or unified in its demands, and feminism's history suggests it has never been able to be both at once.

## Quick recall

- Sex is biological, gender is constructed — the foundational distinction
- Patriarchy = structural, not individual prejudice
- "The personal is political" brought domestic violence, marital rape and unpaid work into politics
- Strands: liberal (law), socialist (capitalism), radical (patriarchy, private sphere), post-modern (the category itself)
- Gilman: economic dependence; socialise domestic work
- de Beauvoir: "one is not born, but rather becomes, a woman"; woman as the Other

- Millett: patriarchy as the most fundamental division; cultural revolution in personal life
- Rowbotham: capitalism depends on unpaid domestic labour; recovering women's history
- hooks: intersectionality; the critique of Friedan's generalisation
- Legal remedy worked on legal barriers; the private sphere has barely moved